

Sin



A full target, and not one arrow in it. The arrows are in the grass. Missing is the point of the drawing, including the shots we never took.

OPEN PART II BY SAYING

Good news is only good if the bad news is true. These five weeks name sin, death, wrath, judgment, and a real guilty verdict. Do not shrink them into low self-esteem. Do not end the night without pointing to Christ.

Before you gather

- Read Day 5, Sin, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Matthew 5:21–22, 27–28 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

What rule did you break as a kid, sure that no one would notice?

Leader. Laugh and move. Do not collect shame stories. Then open Matthew 5. Jesus says the heart misses before the hands do. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: These arrows are not close. Sin is falling short of God's glory, not falling short of the person beside you.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Sin is any failure to conform to the moral law of God in act, attitude, or nature, whether by doing what God forbids or failing to do what He commands.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek hamartia — to miss the mark, to err, to trespass.

MEMORY VERSE · ROMANS 3:23

For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.

Together, open the flashcard for Sin. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Matthew 5:21–22, 27–28

Stay in the Sermon on the Mount. Jesus moves the line from the act to the heart. Ask what He says. Do not turn the hour into a confession performance, and do not reteach the journal.

You have heard that it was said to those of old, “You shall not murder; and whoever murders will be liable to judgment.” But I say to you that everyone who is angry with his brother will be liable to judgment. You have heard that it was said, “You shall not commit adultery.” But I say to you that everyone who looks at a woman with lustful intent has already committed adultery with her in his heart.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. According to Jesus, when is a person already off the mark: only when the act happens, or earlier? **CORE**

Leader. Earlier. Anger with a brother is already liable to judgment. Looking with lustful intent is already adultery in the heart. The heart is guilty before the hands move.

2. Who is Jesus talking to: obvious criminals, or people who thought they were keeping the commands?

Leader. He says, ‘You have heard that it was said.’ These are people who knew the Law and thought they were hitting it. Respectable missing still misses. The standard is God’s, not the group’s.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. James 4:17 says that whoever knows the right thing to do and fails to do it, for him it is sin. Why do we prosecute loud sins and ignore what we never did?

Leader. We name what we did. God also names what we withheld: truth, help, worship, justice. Omission is sin. Sin is any failure to conform to God's law, in act, attitude, or nature.

4. Romans 3:23 says all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God. Why do we prefer to grade ourselves against other people? CORE

Leader. Comparison lets us feel like we almost hit it. The standard is God's glory, His own character. Everyone falls short. There is no curve. All means all.

5. 1 John 1:8-9 says that if we say we have no sin we deceive ourselves, and if we confess, God is faithful to forgive. Why does this room stay polished?

Leader. Image, leadership, family roles. You are not asking anyone to dump a secret. Confession is to God, for forgiveness through the blood of Jesus. It is not group therapy. We name sin in order to bring it to Christ.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Sin is missing God's mark in what we do, what we want, and what we leave undone.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Ask a friend far from Jesus what they think is wrong with the world, and listen. Then own one real way you miss God's mark, and say Jesus came to die for sinners.

Leader. Your own honest miss keeps this from sounding like an attack on them. Still name Christ. A kind conversation that never says Jesus came for sinners is not the whole challenge. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Lord, show us Your glory as the real target, not a softer one we invented.
2. We confess that we have sinned in what we did, in what we wanted, and in what we left undone.
3. Thank You that Jesus came to die for sinners. Do not leave us under the verdict without the Savior.

Before you stumble

Part II begins. Say that before the icebreaker. Watch two errors. Some will over-talk their failures to prove they are sincere. Thank them, and say we name sin to bring it to Christ, not to perform it. Some will shrink sin to the big list. Read Matthew 5 again. Do not turn the hour into journaling.

WITH STUDENTS

Have them finish this sentence: 'I would never do that, so I am fine.' Then reread Matthew 5:21-22 and 27-28 and ask what Jesus would say back. Let the text answer.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Genesis 3:1-13, if you want the first miss as a story. Ask one question: where do they hide, and from whom? Do not allegory it to death. God still comes looking. The promise of a Deliverer is in the same chapter.

